

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

W E D N E S D A Y , M A R C H 2 5 , 2 0 2 6

Strapped towns cross fingers on override votes

Record-setting requests to exceed property tax limits

By James Vaznis
GLOBE STAFF

Records are often poised to be broken, and this spring property tax hikes in Massachusetts are no exception.

Arlington residents will vote Saturday on a \$14.8 million property tax override, the biggest in the state if passed, in an effort to prevent widespread school and town job cuts. The Brookline Select Board might place an even larger override on its town ballot in May that could include two options, \$18.6 million and \$23.25 million, to prevent school and town staff reductions.

And Malden is breaking a record this month it long had been proud of: Never asking residents to support an override for the city's operating budgets. At the annual election on March 31, voters will confront two override options, \$5.4 million or \$8.2 million, to prevent deep cuts to city services.

Local officials say they tried to avoid the controversial overrides and keep the tax hikes as low as possible, but they have cut their budgets significantly, costs keep rising, and now it's time for voters to weigh in.

Communities need voter approval for the tax hikes because a state law, known as Proposition 2½, largely limits the amount of property tax revenue that can be raised annually to no more than 2.5 percent. But costs for many municipalities and schools are rising at faster rates, including health insurance coverage for

OVERRIDES, Page A6

With big field, plenty of choice in Sixth District Democratic race

By Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

More than a decade ago, voters on Massachusetts' North Shore picked a change agent over the consummate insider for Congress. This year, they're facing a similar choice — and their decision could reveal how voters are feeling about the future of the Democratic Party.

Eight Democrats have launched bids to replace Representative Seth Moulton after he gave up a safe blue House seat to mount a run against Senator Ed Markey. The Sixth Congressional District primary field features a mix of longtime political animals, including a White House alum and current and former state representatives, as well as an array of first-time candidates.

Front of mind is Dan Koh, a former Biden administration official, aide to former mayor Martin J. Walsh, and 2018 congressional candidate already drawing attacks from his competitors. The 41-year-old vastly outraised his opponents in the early throes of the primary, is backed by national party leaders such as former vice president Kamala Harris, and is pitching his deep familiarity with Washington as an asset.

The other seven Democrats running are betting the race will come down to who can reinvigorate voters in a party disappointed with its leadership.

SIXTH DISTRICT, Page A7

AI offers hope of college prep for all

Much less expensive but counselors fear loss of human touch

By Mariana Simões
GLOBE STAFF

Devonte Teixeira, a junior at Charlestown High School, needs more help navigating college applications than the five counselors juggling hundreds of students at his school can provide.

Without money to hire an outside

consultant, Teixeira downloaded Apply Genius, an AI-powered college counselor he heard about at camp last summer. Charlestown High has a better counselor-to-student ratio than many schools, but kids and guidance staff are busy, and artificial intelligence can provide immediate answers around the clock.

"It's faster than waiting three days for an email reply from a human," Teixeira said. "My counselor is great, but they have lots of other students."

A growing number of AI-powered

chatbots that churn out college advice promise to solve the chronic shortage of overtaxed school counselors in Massachusetts public schools. Education companies are marketing the AI college counselor as a technology that levels the playing field for kids in underserved communities who can't afford outside help.

Skeptics caution that artificial intelligence cannot replicate the empathy and personalized support of a human counselor. School guidance staff bring a deep knowledge of family dy-

namics and social pressures, offering insights that extend far beyond the bullet points on a student's resume.

Families with resources have long paid college consultants to give their children extra attention. But now companies such as Kollegio, which boasts of giving students free advice worth up to \$10,000, say they are "democratizing" college counseling by making it accessible to all. Last year the company reported that 66 percent of students using the platform come from households that

COLLEGE PREP, Page A7

READY FOR THEIR CLOSE-UP



JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

A group of horticulturalists and volunteers worked Tuesday to move bright orange nasturtiums to the courtyard at the Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum. Gardner began the tradition of transforming the courtyard for her birthday in April. **B3.**

Deep love and respect for Chavez turns to revulsion after allegations of abuse

In Providence, a move to rename street, remove statue

By Edward Fitzpatrick
GLOBE STAFF

PROVIDENCE — As a Mexican American growing up in El Paso, Marta V. Martinez had deep respect for César Chavez, the legendary farm labor leader and civil rights activist.

Her uncle was a leader of a regional union who worked with Chavez. Her mother attended his rallies. And after moving to Rhode Island, Martinez — a former journalist who founded Rhode Island Latino Arts — created a nonprofit

scholarship fund in Chavez's name.

"He was a hero," she said of Chavez, the United Farm Workers cofounder who became one of the most consequential figures in Mexican American history before he died in 1993 at age 66.

But in response to allegations that Chavez sexually abused girls and women, Martinez decided to dissolve the nonprofit she created in Chavez's name. And now she is advocating for stripping away other honors: renaming the Providence street dedicated to him, and removing the statue of him in Davis Park.

"It was shocking," Martinez said of the allegations detailed by The New York Times last week.

The allegations prompted officials in other states to contemplate

or begin to remove his name from public places, as well as to rename César Chavez Day, March 31, as Farmworkers Day. The Associated Press identified more than 130 locations or objects in at least 19 states named after Chavez, including libraries, streets, and parks.

Martinez, who also established Nuestras Raíces: The Latino Oral History Project of Rhode Island, said she created a scholarship in Chavez's name in 2004 "to honor values I believed defined that legacy: nonviolence, sacrifice, and a commitment to uplifting our community."

But now, "I have had to reflect more honestly on the full story — on what happens when power is mis-

CHAVEZ, Page A6

POINT OF VIEW: DEVRA FIRST

The revelation of Rene Redzepi's abuse "forces those who appreciate and want to patronize ambitious, chef-driven restaurants to face a moral conundrum: Does doing so make us complicit in a system where success comes at the expense of those who help create it?" **G1.**

Travel disruptions deepened as senators raced to salvage a proposal to end the Homeland Security shutdown. **A2.**

A friendly soccer match between Brazil and France at Gillette Stadium on Thursday will be a dress rehearsal for the MBTA as it prepares for the World Cup in June. **B1.**

Airstrikes battered Iran while Iranian missiles and drones targeted Israel and sites across the Mideast, even as President Trump said the US was in talks to end the war. **A4.**

A matter of degrees

Wednesday: Some sun, decent. High 49-54. Low 38-43.

Thursday: Cloudy, rain late. High 58-63. Low 47-52.

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

VOL. 309, NO. 84

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



Weeks after tragedy, they find healing in hockey



KEN MCGAGH FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Colin Dorgan and his Blackstone Valley Co-op team were welcomed by David Pastrnak and the rest of the Bruins.

TARA SULLIVAN

On Monday afternoon, as Colin Dorgan sat with his Blackstone Valley Co-op team at the Bruins' practice facility, his sister, Ava, had no trouble spying him from the mezzanine above the stands. Nearly a head taller than many of his teammates, Colin could be easily spotted in the group pounding the boards for every Bruin taking the ice or jumping out of his seat with every whizzing puck.

But, really, this big sister would see him no matter his physical stature. For the past five heartbreaking weeks, she's watched him do nothing but rise above.

Monday's invitation was the Bruins' way of celebrating one of Rhode Island's newest high school state champions, of welcoming a team that just five weeks earlier, on a Monday night

inside a Pawtucket hockey arena, had its world shattered by unthinkable violence.

Colin Dorgan is the face of that tragic night, on the ice while his mother, Rhonda Dorgan, brother, Aidan Dorgan, grandparents, and a family friend were shot in the stands by his father, who would later die by suicide. Rhonda, Aidan, and grandfather Gerald Dorgan all died from their wounds.

Somehow, Colin managed to return to the ice, and with his Blackstone Valley teammates at his side, with his beloved family members in his heart, he led the Knights all the way to a title. He scored four goals over the team's final three games, including one that won a game in double overtime and another that tied a game with 32.2 seconds to go.

He rose above.

"I'm just really proud of him," Ava said.

SULLIVAN, Page C6